

ACCELATHON — Competitor Guide

Overview

Accelathon is a one-day, AI-focused hackathon hosted by the Claremont Accelerator. The goal is simple: build a real, working product in a single day.

You are here to:

- Build something real
 - Move fast
 - Ship a working demo
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Core Philosophy

- Building > ideation
 - Execution > slides
 - Real problems > hypothetical ideas
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Schedule

- **10:30 AM** — Check-in + lunch
- **11:00 AM** — Claude Code workshop (how to build with AI)
- **11:30 AM** — Design thinking workshop
- **12:00 PM** — Prompt + theme revealed
- **12:00–6:00 PM** — Build phase
- **6:00–7:00 PM** — Judging + final presentations

You must be present for judging to be eligible for prizes.

Prompt & Theme

You will **not** know the prompt ahead of time.

It will be revealed at **12:00 PM**.
Make sure you are there.

Build Expectations

You are required to build a **working prototype or demo**.

- This is not a pitch competition
- Slides alone are not enough
- Even non-technical teams must produce something functional

If you don't know how to build:

- Attend the **11:00 AM Claude Code workshop**
 - You will learn how to go from idea to an app quickly
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Tools & Resources

You are allowed to use:

- Any APIs
- Any software/tools
- The internet

During the event:

- We will provide \$20 API keys for teams without Claude access
- These will be explained during the workshop

Recommended approach:

- Move fast
 - Build scrappy
 - Focus on a demo that works
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Teams

- Teams can be any size (2–5 recommended)

- You can form teams before or at the event
- If you don't have a team, we will match you Saturday morning

If you need to change your team:

- Email us before the event
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Rules

- **No pre-built or previous projects allowed**
 - All work must be done during the event
 - You must present to be eligible for prizes
 - We will be checking for violations
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Judging Format

Each team will:

- Give a **3-minute pitch**
- Answer **1 minute of Q&A**

Judging will happen:

- In private rooms
 - In front of professors, professionals, and a VC
 - Presentations will be recorded
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Judging Criteria

Each project is evaluated on:

- Problem clarity and importance
- Solution quality
- Technical depth
- Execution and demo quality
- Design and usability
- Team insight / founder-market fit

Focus on:

- Showing a real problem
 - Demonstrating a working solution
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Prizes

There are **5 total prizes**:

- **1st Place** — \$2,500
- **2nd Place** — \$1,000
- **3rd Place** — \$500
- **Best Design Thinking** — \$500
- **Best Technical Depth** — \$500

Winning teams also receive:

- Final-round interviews for the Claremont Accelerator cohort
 - Access to mentorship, funding, and long-term support
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Submission Requirements

All teams must submit:

- Slide deck
- Demo video
- Short written description

Submission link: TBD

Logistics

- You are **not required to stay onsite all day**
- You **must return for judging**

Food provided:

- Lunch (Chipotle)

- Dinner (Panda Express)
 - Snacks + caffeine throughout
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Workshops (Important)

11:00 AM — Claude Code Workshop

- Learn how to build apps using AI
- Especially useful for non-technical participants

11:30 AM — Design Thinking Workshop

- Learn how to identify real problems
- Structure your solution effectively

These workshops are designed to make sure *everyone* can build.

Communication

Before the event:

- Email us with questions or team changes

During the event:

- All updates will be sent via email
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FAQ

Do I need to stay the whole time?

No, but you must be back for judging.

Can I use something I built before?

No. All work must be done during the event.

What if I don't know how to code?

Come to the 11:00 AM workshop. We'll teach you how to build using AI tools.

When does the hackathon end?

Building ends at 6:00 PM. Judging and finals run from 6:00–7:00 PM.

When do we find out the prompt?

12:00 PM on the day of the event.

How do API keys work?

We'll provide keys to teams that need them and explain everything during the workshop.

What if I don't have a team?

We'll match you at the start of the event.

Can I change my team?

Yes, just email us ahead of time.